

2.1 Windows Vista: A Troubled Journey

Windows Vista has been Microsoft's most disparaged project yet. The freshly-squeezed OS has been labelled many things: from nothing more than a pretty skin on Windows XP to a complete disaster in terms of consumer traction and appeal. The truth lies buried beneath the pile of rubble that has been bad press for Microsoft in general, and bitter aftertaste from the Microsoft anti-trust legacy.

Vista started off as perhaps the most ambitious vision that the Redmond giant has dared to dream. With time, that vision had to take a back seat to reality and what has finally been released has disappointed many. Before we get into the innards of this new operating system, to understand exactly what has changed and what those changes entail, let's take a quick look at how we came to Vista.

Flashback to 2001, when Windows XP was about to be released to the world. In typical Silicon Valley fashion, whispers of the next OS from Microsoft were already doing the Internet rounds. Back then, the codename for the OS was Longhorn, and Longhorn was slated as the interim release between Vista and the next major release of Windows termed Blackcomb. For the curious: these codenames are derived from geographical locations around British Columbia—Blackcomb was a ski resort, much like Whistler (the codename for Windows XP), while Longhorn was a strip of earth that you needed to traverse to get to Blackcomb from Whistler—the codenames were thus emblems of intent for the OS in question, and somewhat poetic.

Vista, or Longhorn back then, was a bit more ambitious than the product we now see on retail shelves. The idea was to create an operating system for the new age—one that would intelligently store your data, and route it transparently from locale to locale as you moved computers. It was meant to leverage several technologies including a SQL database for storing disparate content; a com-